

Introduction

Almost 15 years ago, in the depths of the great recession, I expressed my thoughts on Leadership in the article below. As I was rereading it recently I realized the basic ideas are as important today as ever. Great leaders do not take counsel from their fears. Hiccups in the stock market are an item for reflection, not anxiety. Success in a rising market is encouraging, but it is a not a green light to ignore business fundamentals and financial prudence. Leadership is as much about steadfastness as anything else.

I encourage you to read and consider the article below and share with any of your employees who have leadership responsibilities of their own. Please let me know what you think.

All my best,
Al T.

A Half Dozen (More or Less) Thoughts on Leadership

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Whether you are a squad leader responsible for 10 soldiers, the teacher with a class of 20 students, the manager of 100 workers at a Red Lobster, principal of a 500-student high school, the CEO of 2000 employees in a mid-sized corporation, mayor of a city with 10,000 residents, or the President of the United States, it's lonely at the top. Yet certain basic tenets apply to the role of leader- guidance which exists to make the lonely job easier.

The basic principals and tenets of leadership are constant. Yet an ever changing world dictates that we constantly reassess these fundamentals in the hopes of finding new applications and utility for their timeless wisdom.

1. Set the example - Authority can be given, but respect must always be earned. One cannot ask for sacrifice if they are unwilling to sacrifice themselves. Demonstrate flexibility and preparedness to instill the importance of these attributes in your subordinates. "Do as I say, not as I do" is almost always a recipe for ruin.
2. Whenever possible, explain – Not all situations allow for explanation, nor is one necessarily required - but almost everyone responds better to direction when they understand the reasoning behind the command.
3. Never display uncertainty - Once you have collected the facts and made a decision don't waffle. Often a less than optimal choice, well planned and executed, will result in a successful outcome.
4. When circumstances change, be prepared to change with them - Even the best decisions may have to be modified, or even reversed, as facts and situations are altered. Good leaders recognize a shifting environment, and are not afraid that changing their position appropriately will be viewed as flip flopping. Stubbornness is no more a virtue than indecisiveness.
5. Be objective – We all have our own biases and issues. To be a great leader is to acknowledge your preconceptions and prejudices, and make sure you always do your best to put them aside.
6. Try to be fair and equitable, but remember that it is not always possible – The leader's job often requires that he asks others to sacrifice disproportionately, for it is

his responsibility to put the best people in the position where they have the greatest opportunity to accomplish the mission. This may result in situations where some appear to be treated better than others. Yet, while fairness is a desired outcome, it should never be the underlying motivation of the leader. Good leaders do what must be done for all to succeed.

7. You can't change what you don't understand - To change a person's behavior or an organizations culture requires the investment of time and thought necessary to truly comprehend the existing circumstances. First impressions can be deceiving, and good leaders understand their obligation to have and understand all the facts available before making decisions and developing strategies. Bad decisions which are the result of inadequate research or review must be seen as a failure of leadership to fulfill one of its most important responsibilities.